

A HEROINE REDEFINED

Many layers of the Mahabharata unfold as a rebellious Draupadi recounts her dramatic life story



THE PALACE OF ILLUSIONS

by CHITRA BANERJEE DIVAKARUNI

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■ By Gillian Wright

Publishers have a tendency to be princes among men, I believe, because books are ennobling. However their hackles can rise and recently I saw the eyes of one leading Delhi publisher ablaze with wrath at reviewers who revealed the plots of his newly published novels. He seemed to regard this as akin to infanticide. So it was with some trepidation that I picked up Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni's latest book, determined not to give any hints about the denouement. Luckily everyone will know the plot. In fact, it's been drummed into us all, very thoroughly, through spoken and written word and particularly by B.R. Chopra and his scriptwriter Rahi Masoom Raza.

The Palace of Illusions is a novel based on the Mahabharata. It is different because it is Draupadi's story. Written in the first person, Draupadi recounts the epic from the time she and her brother Drishtadyumna are born out of the sacrificial fire and adopted by King Drupad.

The author has already notched up a series of bestsellers including *The Mistress of Spices* which was turned into an undistinguished film starring Aishwarya Rai. She also teaches creative writing at the University of Houston. In this novel she has adopted a very simple, lucid prose style. Each word is carefully considered as her heroine unfolds the different layers of the Mahabharata through conversations, stories and dreams. Divakaruni is helped by the fact that the Mahabharata itself never pales and can withstand any amount of retelling.

Her Draupadi is in many ways a modern woman rebelling against the fact that the major decisions in her life are taken by men without consulting her. She sees that strong women tend to have unhappy marriages, be they Kunti

or Gandhari. And she has the independence of mind to find Gandhari's decision to blindfold herself for life unintelligent.

Seeing everything from Draupadi's point of view provides many opportunities to add to the traditional story. For example the Sanskrit text describes Draupadi on the occasion of her *swayamvara* simply thus: "Even to those who had seen her many times, she appeared eternally new. Without smiling, she seemed to be smiling a heavenly smile. Without drinking wine, she seemed delightfully intoxicated, and without speaking, she seemed to be talking with her eyes." Divakaruni's

owing Bhima's special role as a protector of his wife. Divakaruni's Arjun, however, battles alone. This gives the hero the opportunity to set off alone with Draupadi and to establish some intimacy with her. This nascent relationship is nipped in the bud by Kunti's instruction that all five brothers share her. From the start, Divakaruni chooses to make Kunti Draupadi's adversary.

The dharmic scholar Chaturvedi Badrinath sees the weak arguments put forward by Yudhishtira to justify Draupadi's marriage to five brothers as typical of the universal human trait of always being able to find excuses for doing



EPIC IMAGE: Draupadi's disrobing in B.R. Chopra's TV serial Mahabharat

Draupadi, dark and beautiful, is subject to more varied emotions as she enters the hall where her suitors wait to take the test her father has set them. She is wary, sarcastic, dismayed, romantic and passionate. She rejects Karna not in contempt for his low birth but in panic, fearing that if she did not intervene, Karna would kill her brother.

After Arjun, disguised as a Brahmin, wins her hand, the humiliated Kshatriya suitors take up arms and the *swayamvara* ends in disarray in a mini-Kurukshetra battle. Here Divakaruni removes a character from the action. In the original text Bhima and Arjun both fight off the enraged princes, foreshad-

what you want to do. He goes back to the Sanskrit text to demonstrate that the real reason for the marriage was that from the moment they first saw her all five brothers found "all their senses churned by Manmatha" and desired Draupadi feverishly.

Unlike Badrinath, Divakaruni does not make her Mahabharata an enquiry into the human condition. Instead, she emphasises the individuality of her main characters, particularly her heroine and the Pandavas, making them realistic and many-sided. While their destiny remains unchanged, she gives a 21st-century flavour to the epic as well as some surprises, although these—out of consideration for the publisher and reader—are best left unrevealed here. ■